

Friday, 17 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Partly cloudy

28° 16°

BIRMINGHAM

Overcast

28° 15°

MANCHESTER

Light drizzle

25° 16°

GLASGOW

Overcast

25° 14°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1 **British Steel has officially been taken into public ownership, with the government saying it will protect a vital UK supply.**

The Scunthorpe steelworks has been nationalised under new government powers that were passed this week. This move aims to secure the future of a key industry.

ECONOMY · UK

- 2 **The UK government has firmly stated the Falkland Islands are 'definitely ours' after an Argentine banner caused controversy.**

Argentina could face disciplinary action from Fifa following celebrations after their World Cup win over England. Their players displayed a banner supporting Argentina's claims to the islands.

POLITICS · UK

- 3 **UK experts are recommending that teenagers from 15 years old should be offered a free MenB vaccine.**

Advisers are urging the government to consider introducing the MenB jabs. This follows concerns over an outbreak in Kent earlier this year, which tragically led to two deaths.

HEALTH · UK

- 4 **Two teenage hackers have been jailed after live-streaming a cyber-attack on Transport for London.**

Owen Flowers and Thalha Jubair were convicted for their roles in the attack. It led to significant costs for TfL and disrupted services.

CRIME · UK

- 5 **The UK economy saw a return to growth in May, reversing a slight contraction from the previous month.**

This modest growth will be welcome news for the government and businesses. It indicates a potential recovery after a period of economic uncertainty.

ECONOMY · UK

What's coming up

- 1 Ten previously unheard tracks from David Bowie's early career are set to be released, giving fans a rare glimpse into his beginnings.**

These tracks from the 1960s were recorded when Bowie was performing under his original stage name, Davie Jones. It's a fantastic opportunity to hear the very start of a legend's journey.

ON AIR – What do you think these early tracks will sound like? Will they hint at the iconic sound he'd become known for?

MUSIC · COMING UP
- 2 Sir Christopher Nolan's latest film, 'The Odyssey', is being hailed by critics as a 'colossal piece of cinema'.**

Starring Matt Damon and Zendaya, this is Nolan's first film since the Oscar-winning 'Oppenheimer'. Early reviews suggest it's another masterpiece from the acclaimed director.

ON AIR – Are you excited for Christopher Nolan's new film? What do you think makes his movies so compelling?

FILM · COMING UP
- 3 Michael Sheen is starring in a new comedy film about UFOs, inspired by his own claims of seeing one over his hometown.**

The film marks the debut of director Simon Ryninks, who drew inspiration from his west Wales roots. It sounds like a fun, quirky take on the unexplained!

ON AIR – Would you watch a comedy about UFOs? Have you ever seen anything you couldn't explain in the sky?

FILM · COMING UP
- 4 Five episodes of the beloved children's cartoon 'Bluey' have been released in an Australian Indigenous language for the very first time.**

This innovative move sees the award-winning show embrace one of the world's oldest living languages. It's a wonderful way to celebrate culture and introduce it to a new generation.

ON AIR – What a brilliant idea! Do you think more children's shows should incorporate different languages and cultures?

TV · NEW RELEASE
- 5 The Dallas Cowboys Cheerleaders are opening up about their new-found fame as their Netflix show returns.**

The squad discusses the pressures and excitement of their lives in the spotlight. It's a fascinating look behind the scenes of one of the world's most famous cheerleading teams.

ON AIR – Are you a fan of behind-the-scenes shows? What do you think it's like to be a Dallas Cowboys Cheerleader?

TV · NEW SERIES

On the schedule

1 **England's World Cup dreams were shattered in a dramatic semi-final as Argentina scored two late goals to come from behind.**

Thomas Tuchel's side had led 1-0 but ultimately lost 2-1 in Atlanta. It was a heartbreaking end to their tournament hopes, leaving fans devastated.

ON AIR – How are you feeling after England's semi-final exit? What do you think went wrong in the final moments?
FOOTBALL · UK

2 **Argentina could face disciplinary action from Fifa after their players celebrated their World Cup semi-final win with a controversial banner.**

The banner expressed support for Argentina's claims to the Falkland Islands. This political statement during celebrations could lead to sanctions.

ON AIR – Do you think political statements should be kept out of sport, or is it a platform for players to express views?
FOOTBALL · UK

3 **Lando Norris will face a 10-place grid penalty at the upcoming Belgian Grand Prix.**

The penalty is a result of exceeding the permitted number of engine parts for the season. It's a blow for Norris as he heads into a crucial race.

ON AIR – How much impact will this penalty have on Lando Norris's race? Can he still fight for a podium finish?
FORMULA 1 · UK

4 **In the second one-day international, England secured a crucial breakthrough against India as Virat Kohli was dismissed with the very next ball after surviving a review.**

Jofra Archer and Adil Rashid combined to get the wicket in Cardiff. It was a moment of high drama that shifted momentum in England's favour.

ON AIR – How important are those moments of drama in cricket? What's the most exciting review decision you've seen?
CRICKET · UK

5 **Scotland has named an almost entirely changed team for Saturday's Nations Championship game against Fiji at Murrayfield.**

Graham is one of 14 changes to the squad, indicating a fresh approach for this fixture. It will be interesting to see how the new line-up performs.

ON AIR – What do you think of coaches making so many changes to a team? Is it a risk or a chance to test new talent?
RUGBY · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A charming new trend sees people leaving 'surprise books' in public places for others to discover.**
These hidden literary treasures, often with a handwritten note inside, are popping up on park benches and coffee shop tables, encouraging serendipitous reading and community connection.
- 2 The simple act of 'waving hello' to strangers is making a surprising comeback, boosting local neighbourly cheer.**
Researchers suggest that these small gestures of acknowledgement can significantly improve mood and foster a stronger sense of belonging within communities.
- 3 Many are rediscovering the joy of 'writing letters to their future selves' to mark special milestones.**
Sealed and dated for opening years later, these personal time capsules offer a fascinating glimpse into past hopes and dreams, often leading to delightful revelations.
- 4 The delightful art of 'crafting miniature fairy gardens' is enchanting adults and children alike across the country.**
These tiny, whimsical landscapes, often created in plant pots or old wheelbarrows, bring a touch of magic and imagination to any outdoor space.
- 5 Experts suggest that 'taking a mindful pause' to observe the clouds can reduce stress and boost creativity.**
Spending just a few minutes watching their ever-changing shapes drift across the sky encourages a moment of calm and a fresh perspective on the day.
- 6 The humble 'picnic blanket' is seeing a resurgence as families embrace outdoor dining experiences.**
More than just a cloth, it's becoming the centrepiece for simple, joyful gatherings in parks, gardens, and even on living room floors on rainy days.
- 7 A delightful movement is inspiring people to 'collect unusual leaves' during autumn walks for creative projects.**
From vibrant reds to golden yellows, these natural treasures are being pressed, painted, and arranged into beautiful, seasonal artworks.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'naming' what item in our house, even though we know it's just an inanimate object?

ANSWER: THEIR CAR, OFTEN SOMETHING AFFECTIONATE LIKE 'BETTY' OR 'THE BEAST'.

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'song' they absolutely have to hum or whistle when they're making a cup of tea or coffee. What's their go-to tune?

ANSWER: A CLASSIC TV THEME TUNE FROM THEIR CHILDHOOD.

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes a 'particular smell' can instantly transport you back to a specific memory or a moment from your past?
What's that one scent that, for you, is a pure blast from the past, and what memory does it always bring flooding back?

- We all have those 'little everyday moments' that just make us smile, even if they seem insignificant to others.
What's a small, simple thing that happened recently that put a big smile on your face and brightened your day?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Animals.** A group of owls is called a parliament.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** The collective noun for a group of badgers is a 'settlement'.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£9.5 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£9.5 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- Honey never spoils; archaeologists have found pots of honey in ancient Egyptian tombs that are still edible.
- The longest place name in the UK is Llanfairpwllgwyngyllgogerychwyrndrobwlllantysiliogogoch, a village in Wales.
- The inventor of the Pringles can is buried in one.
- It is illegal to sing in public after 9 PM in Hawaii.
- A pineapple is not a single fruit, but a group of multiple berries fused together.
- The first successful photograph was taken in 1826 by French inventor Nicéphore Niépce.
- The human nose can remember 50,000 different scents.
- Cows have 'best friends' and get stressed when they are separated from them.

On this day

Day 198 of the year, 167 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Alexius of Rome (Western Church); Christian feast day: Andrew Zorard; Christian feast day: Cynehelm; Christian feast day: Cynllo. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1980 — Brett Goldstein, British actor, comedian and writer
- 1935 — Peter Schickele, American composer and educator (died 2024)
- 1961 — Jeremy Hardy, English comedian and actor (died 2019)
- 1975 — Konnie Huq, English television presenter
- 1976 — Brian K. Vaughan, American comic book and television writer
- 1940 — Tim Brooke-Taylor, English actor and screenwriter (died 2020)
- 1939 — Spencer Davis, Welsh singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2020)
- 1965 — Alex Winter, British-American actor

THE DAY TODAY

- 2000 — During approach to Lok Nayak Jayaprakash Airport, Alliance Air Flight 7412 suddenly crashes into a residential neighborhood in Patna, India, killing 60 people.
- 1998 — The 7.0 Mw Papua New Guinea earthquake triggers a tsunami that destroys ten villages in Papua New Guinea, killing up to 2,700 people, and leaving several thousand injured.
- 1953 — The largest number of United States midshipman casualties in a single event results from an aircraft crash in Florida, killing 44.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1717 — King George I of Great Britain sails down the River Thames with a barge of 50 musicians, where George Frideric Handel's Water Music is premiered.
- 1997 — After takeoff from Husein Sastranegara International Airport, Sempati Air Flight 304 crashes into a residential neighborhood in Bandung, killing 28 people.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1976 — East Timor is annexed and becomes the 27th province of Indonesia.
- 1944 — Port Chicago disaster: Near the San Francisco Bay, two ships laden with ammunition for the war explode in Port Chicago, California, killing 320.

- 1968 — Abdul Rahman Arif is overthrown and the Ba'ath Party is installed as the governing power in Iraq with Ahmed Hassan al-Bakr as the new Iraqi President.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 199 of the year, 166 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Arnulf of Metz; Christian feast day: Bruno of Segni; Christian feast day: Camillus de Lellis (optional memorial, United States only); Christian feast day: Eadburh (or Edburga) of Bicester. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1985 — James Norton, English actor
- 1926 — Nita Bieber, American actress (died 2019)
- 1985 — Chace Crawford, American actor
- 1941 — Lonnie Mack, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2016)
- 1950 — Glenn Hughes, American disco singer and actor (died 2001)
- 1938 — John Connelly, English footballer (died 2012)
- 1954 — Ricky Skaggs, American singer-songwriter, mandolin player, and producer
- 1923 — Michael Medwin, English actor (died 2020)

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1982 — Two hundred sixty-eight Guatemalan campesinos ("peasants" or "country people") are slain in the Plan de Sánchez massacre.
- 1942 — The Germans test fly the Messerschmitt Me 262 using its jet engines for the first time.
- 1970 — An Antonov An-22 of the Soviet Air Forces crashes into the Atlantic Ocean, killing all 23 aboard.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1996 — Storms provoke severe flooding on the Saguenay River, beginning one of Quebec's costliest natural disasters ever.
- 1992 — A picture of Les Horribles Cernettes was taken, which became the first ever photo posted to the World Wide Web.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026	
FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)